

5.1 Evolution & Functionality

The traditional way of networking is client-server architecture. In this type, there are dedicated computers (servers) which let other computers (clients) access it and use its resources. In the P2P type, all computers are connected to a network and at any point of time any computer can act as a server and another computer that uses its resources is the client.

Peer-to-peer file-sharing is based on this protocol. When you install software such as Napster or Kazaa on your computer and access the Internet, it connects to other computers to download any stuff that you have searched using the client.

Based on this protocol, Napster was launched in May 1999. This was the first P2P software but not in the truest sense of the word. This was because it still needed users to connect to a central server and once the client was identified, further file transfer was passed on to the nodes. This was furthered by software such as Kazaa and eDonkey. However, with each new software came a different implementation of the technology. We will talk about this when we go and pick apart each of the software.

Since 1999, there have been many changes in the P2P world. Napster has since closed down owing to a ruling by the American courts. Napster is still available, but in a form where it is no longer attractive enough for P2P users.

Newer P2P software such as BitTorrent has reared its head in recent years and is the latest rage amongst P2P users. Filling the gap between Napster and BitTorrent was eDonkey, which was going strong until BitTorrent appeared. eDonkey is still pretty much available, but its favourite rating amongst users has dropped to a very large extent.

In the coming section, we will discuss the most used P2P software worldwide and how to use them. But before you start read-